SUMMARY HANDOUT — CHAPTER 2

Structuring the content

Summary handout — Demo course “Designing an online course”

Contents

- 1. The sequence, the real unit of learning
- 2. Breaking up is not chopping up
- 3. The order of prerequisites, not of importance

Scoping settled for whom and to do what. What remains is deciding in which order, and in what pieces. This is where the difference is made between a course people finish and one they abandon at chapter three.

1. The sequence, the real unit of learning

A chapter is a storage unit; what the learner goes through are **sequences**. A useful sequence carries three parts: a **question** that motivates it, **content** that answers it, a **check** that proves it landed. It is almost always the third that goes missing — it is the hardest to imagine.

2. Breaking up is not chopping up

A five-minute sequence that does not stand on its own is not micro-learning: it is a chapter cut in half. The test: if the learner stops there, do they leave with something usable?

3. The order of prerequisites, not of importance

The most common mistake is opening with what matters most — hence with what assumes everything else. List your notions, draw an arrow from each to those it assumes: notions with no incoming arrow are your starting points. A cycle signals a badly cut notion.

Alternate rather than apportion

The balance between theory and practice is not a matter of proportions but of alternation: a notion, its application, the next notion.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- A sequence: a question, content, a check.
- A short sequence must stand on its own.
- The right order is that of prerequisites.
- What does not serve the through-line is what you cut first.

Mohamed EL AFRIT — CC BY 4.0